



Facebook Camera app

Facebook has announced an app called Camera for iOS devices focussing on viewing and sharing photos

12-35mm f/2.8

Panasonic has announced a new micro four thirds lens called Lumix G Vario 12-35mm F2.8 fast zoom lens

Travelzoom Cameras

FEATURES AND DESIGN

In this category, the Nikon Coolpix S8200 and S6300 sport the highest pixel count of 16 million, with the Samsung WB150F and Panasonic DMC-SZ7 housing a modest 14-megapixel sensor. For some odd reason, the more expensive Panasonic DMC-TZ25 has a lower megapixel count than the SZ-7 (12 vs. 14).

But when considering a travel-zoom to splurge on, the obvious spec we look for would be the optical zoom number. The Samsung WB150F brought a rock solid 18x optically stabi-

lized lens to the game, the star among the competition.

So you have a fat megapixel count and you can zoom till the moon. But can your camera shoot like a machine gun? Apparently it can! Thanks to incorporation of electronic shutters in point-and-shoot cameras, the burst mode on these little things has gone up from a measly 2 FPS to Nikon's claim of 6 FPS, and Panasonic's 10 FPS. There was a time this was possible only in high-end DSLRs and now, for under 17K, even you can shoot off 10 frames per second. Simply amazing. The feature set other than the zoom

and megapixel count on all the cameras is fairly standard, except that the Panasonic DMC-TZ25 has a touch screen that can be used to work with the menu and select the focusing point.

ERGONOMICS

Before you finally spend that hard earned cash on the camera you're supposedly lusting for, wouldn't you love to hold and see if it feels right? We know we would. One of the most important aspects of being able to take good photos is making sure that the camera fits well in your hands, that the buttons and menus on the camera can

be easily accessed with minimal camera movement. The dimensions of the camera relative to the size of your hand matters, as does the weight of the camera.

In our testing, we found that the Nikon Coolpix S6300 felt like a cheap toy camera. Its plastic build did not feel sturdy at all and every time we opened the battery compartment to swap out the battery, we felt that it might just snap off. The Nikon Coolpix S8200, though heavier and longer (and even having a much better build) did not give us any mental ease about its capabilities of withstanding an accidental fall. The

HOW WE TESTED

We broke up the category into two segments; Cameras below ₹16,000 and cameras above ₹17,000. We broke up our testing into two types; "real world photos" and "studio setups". For the real world test, we strolled over to a garden close-by for its varied offerings of texture, architecture, people, foliage and landscape. For each shot that was taken, the camera was tripod mounted, switched to Program mode (if available). White balance was left on Auto to gauge color rendition under real life situations and ISO was set to 400. The first test involved testing the image quality (and dynamic range) at both the wide and the maximum optical telephoto length of the camera. Our second test involved testing the camera's ability to capture detail and



Studio setup for performance test

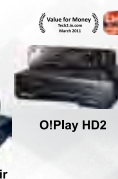
texture, along with seeing how much distortion is generated at the widest angle of the camera. The third test involved a simple macro shot of a flower. Thankfully, there was no wind, so we didn't have to worry about movement on the flower's part. The macro test allowed us to not only gauge each camera's minimum focusing distance,

but also the pixel quality of images shot at close up distances. Our fourth and final test was shooting bright screen foliage that was in shade, with the sun right in front of us. The idea is to see how well the camera can judge the shadow areas and then expose for them, while recreating accurate greens and retaining detail in the shadows and highlight areas.

The second leg involved shooting a studio setup of objects that help evaluate aspects of center and edge sharpness, flash effectiveness, ISO performance, detail retention and color reproduction. While judging ISO performance for us was the retention of detail. We used the text on the crayon labels as a guide to how much detail was preserved after in-camera noise reduction was applied.

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